



The Khumbu Glacier

A large, partly rock-covered glacier in Nepal, famous mainly because it lies on some popular routes for approaching and climbing Mount Everest

The Khumbu Glacier has two main parts (see panel, below). Its upper part, on the western flank of Mount Everest (see pp.226–27), is a colossal icefall—a steeply descending, deeply crevassed mass of broken ice. With its source area at 24,900 ft (7,600 m), the ice moves downhill relatively fast, at about 3¼ ft (1 m) per day. As a result, large crevasses can open up with little or no warning. Smaller ones can become buried under the snow, creating treacherous snow bridges through which unwary climbers can fall. Crossing the icefall is a dangerous exercise, but much of the route up and down is along ladders and ropes that are attached each year by experienced guides.

▽ SPIKY SHARDS

Seracs (towers of ice) commonly develop on the Khumbu Glacier and can fall at any moment, sending large blocks of ice tumbling down the steep slopes.



▷ MORNING DESCENT

A line of climbers can be spotted descending the icefall. Early morning, when the ice is at its most stable, is a favored time for moving on it.



Crevasses in the Khumbu Icefall can be as deep as **165 ft (50 m)** or more

THE KHUMBU GLACIER IN PROFILE

The glacier has two parts: the steeply declining, chaotically crevassed Khumbu Icefall at its top end, which forms part of one of the main routes to Everest; and the gently inclined lower part, which is covered in rock debris and descends down a long, straight-sided approach valley.

